

Reconstructing the Nation and Modernizing Society:

The Socio-Cultural Impact of the Government-Led Housing Plan During

South Korea's Five-Year Plans (1962–1966) in Modern-Day Seoul

1. Project Overview and Introduction

This research explores the housing supply plan, a key part of South Korea's "National Economic Development" that was divided into 7 stages of Five-Year Plans (1962–1997), focusing on the first stage (1962–1966). After the Korean War, the government aimed to address informal settlements and provide mass housing through apartment complexes, which became a lasting social standard, comprising over 40% of the nation's housing by 2014 (The Seoul Institute, 2014).

Seoul was experiencing rapid population growth; the housing plan was to accommodate those populations with formal housing. Park Chung-hee (1963–1979), who became President of the Republic of Korea through a coup d'état, played a key role in leading the National Economic Plan. (Gelézeau, 2007).

This study focuses on apartment complex constructions: the Mapo Apartment Complex (1964), the first of its kind. The construction was located in the heart of Seoul and is recognized as an influential model of housing development. It played a pivotal role in shaping administrative processes and physical forms that remain prevalent in South Korea today.

This paper will attempt to answer questions step by step by segmenting the topic. The paper begins with a study with a historical background that focuses on specific political and socioeconomic factors that have enabled this large-scale change at home and abroad.

Furthermore, the study seeks to identify who the stakeholders benefiting from it were, and who the people affected were through these housing plans. Moreover, what impact it left on society both in physical and socio-cultural terms focusing on how convenience that apartments have brought and on the other hand, how it has contributed to social division and segregation.

2. Research Questions and Methodology

2.1 Research Questions

The primary question that initiated this research is how these apartment construction projects, carried out over a decade (1962–1971), transformed South Korea's future urban landscape. Below are the specific questions that guide my research, from understanding the background to analyzing their societal impact.

1. What socioeconomic factors enabled this large-scale transformation domestically and internationally?
2. How did the large-scale apartment complex housing plans relate to Korea's modernization and governmental power during that period?
3. Who were the stakeholders benefiting from these government-led housing plans, and who were the individuals affected?
4. What were the physical and socio-cultural impacts of these large-scale apartment complex plans on society?

2.2 Methodology

The research employs mixed methods and uses a case study approach, focusing on two housing plans. To gain background knowledge for a deeper understanding of the topic, this paper examines the historical background with a focus on the socio-political context to understand how large-scale apartment construction became feasible during South Korea's modernization and reconstruction era.

Next, drawing on collected data and resources, the study critically analyzes the concept of modernization in South Korea through a theoretical framework that explores the intersections of modernization, ideology, power, and urban planning. This approach sets the foundation for understanding how these factors interacted to drive strong government-led housing initiatives during the specified period (1962–1971).

The paper will employ mixed methods with a case study focusing on a specific apartment plan. Narrowing down to a case, this research will analyze the interrelationship between ideology, power, and housing supply plan in the context of modernizing and reconstructing the nation with qualitative and quantitative data evidence.

Under the topic, it criticizes with centering theoretical framework with key themes: “reconstructing nation”, “modernization” and “sociocultural impact” of this type of apartment complex in South Korea. Another framework to project these themes is its approach taken which is “government-led projects” to delve into aspects of the decision-making process and government interventions through those two construction plans.

Additionally, the study examines the roles of the government and private sector as key stakeholders, highlighting how their financial involvement in the construction industry led to significant gains for private construction companies. Ultimately, the research evaluates the enduring physical and socio-cultural impacts of these government-led housing plans.

3. Historic Background

To understand the topic, the paper solidifies the argument with historical background and clarifies some of the frameworks that are specific to South Korea. Firstly, it acknowledges that the Korean Peninsula experienced the Korean War (1950-1953) which was an ideological division between two Koreas. Korea peninsula became a stage of ideological power division whereas Soviet forces occupied the Korean Peninsula north of the 38th parallel and U.S. forces occupied the south (Britannica, 2024). The Korean War is closely related to the Cold War which was a tension that occurred due to ideological power games across the globe. In this section, the paper will explore what was the background laid down in South Korea home and abroad that strongly influenced the motivation, process and direction of modernization and national reconstruction.

3.1 Modernization in South Korea

At the beginning stage, modernization in South Korea was strongly tied to foreign aid and especially, United States foreign policy. After the war that destroyed the whole country, South Korea sought for the recovery and reconstruction and at the same time, modernization of the country. "Following liberation from Japanese colonization (1910–1945) and amidst ideological division, South Korea's early leaders, such as President Syngman Rhee (1948–1960)

and Vice President Chang Myon (1960–1962), prioritized modernization and economic development as national goals. President Lee emphasized these goals under the system competition to prove the superiority of Capitalism in South Korea over Communism in North Korea. Vice President Chang also highlighted the slogan “*Economy as Top Priority*” to promote the victory of Capitalism and establish a Free Market Economy in South Korea. Their plans were highly reliant on the United States Foreign Aid for the development of the country (National Institute of Korean History, 2024). South Korea was at the stage where it needed foreign aid to invest and develop the country, especially the United States.

3.2 Shift of Foreign Policy of United States and Rostow’s Modernization Model

United States foreign policy was interconnected with the modernization of South Korea. Abroad, the United States changed its foreign policy from aid to loan emphasizing self-help and encouraging economic development of countries in need. Walt Rostow was a significant contributor to Kennedy's government in the 1950s as an economist and policy advisor for foreign policy. Rostow's Modernization Model is introduced which emphasizes the concept of the “take-off” stage as a precondition for modernization in emerging countries. He is the one who revoked the United States to have their interest in Asian countries where just liberated during Cold War. He believed the success of the economy in these countries are the success of US economic aid and also the ideology of democratic capitalism. He was influential in changing the attitude of United States toward these countries and supporting their economic development not military aid.

His idea on modernization was developed into an influential model that was actively employed by the Korean government, especially through people who studied in the United States. According to Rostow, this "modernization" process is characterized by a crucial "take-off" period of rapid growth stimulated by the expansion in a few key economic sectors (Park, 2001).

In the United States, there was favor and support for people from the military government or military as leadership. Military officials were regarded as appropriate for the new leadership for modernization as they were symbolic as overcoming societal class or strat, and experienced advanced administrative system (Park, 2001).

3.3 Reconstructing and National Economic Development

The National Economic Plan highlights the strong, government-led economic development under the Park Chung-hee regime. The five-year National Economic Development Plan played a critical role in shaping a "Koreanized" model of modernization, characterized by military-style propaganda slogans and an emphasis on outward-oriented economic growth driven by an authoritarian government.

Below are the specific targets of the first stage of the National Economic Development Plan, which facilitated a societal transition from an agriculture-based economy to a manufacturing-oriented one, guided by government slogans. Although the housing plan is not detailed in this section, understanding this historical context is crucial to explaining how the authoritarian approach enabled the housing plans discussed in the case study.

The first stage of National Economic Development (1962-1966) sets “*Modernization of industrial structure and further promotion of self-sustaining economy*” as a basic objective. It was the first plan to set the direction of the national economy and society toward industrialization and modernization with a high annual economic growth rate targeted around 7.1%. The government focused on an increase in productivity and national GDP with active export activities (National Archives, 2024).

In specific, it was to balance the national industry by maximizing the proportion of the secondary industry, which was the lowest at 14.6% of all industries. To realize this goal, the expansion of indirect social capital such as roads, bridges, railroads, and ports, as well as energy sources such as electricity and coal, had to be preceded first (HDEC, 2017).

4. Analysis

With an urgent need for recovery from the Korean War, global ideological competition and financial support for the economic development of the United States due to changes in foreign policy provided a foundation for South Korea to move on toward modernization.

Further, the United States indirectly showed being in favor of military leadership for the Third World where a modern economy was newly planted. From this international atmosphere, President Park was able to gain direct financial and indirect political support for his regime even though he rippled the coup d'état.

4.1 Modernization, Ideology, and Power

Park Chung-hee established an authoritarian government and implemented a government-led modernization strategy, often referred to as the "*Koreanized Model*." On May 16, 1961, the military government under Park pledged to the people of South Korea to "urgently resolve the hardships of people's livelihoods struggling on the line of despair and hunger," framing this as the justification for the revolutionary coup d'état (Valérie, 2007).

To compensate for its lack of democratic legitimacy, the coup government revised the Five-Year Plan, focusing on export-driven growth.

From Rostow's model, supporting national economic development in the Third World was a key strategy for the United States to counter the communist bloc. Rostow argued that the experience of national economic development itself was the best way to safeguard nations from Socialist-Communist ideologies and align them with democratic capitalism (Park, 2001).

Thus, South Korea's successful modernization brought mutual benefits: for the United States, it represented an ideological victory, while for the Korean military government, it helped compensate for the democratic legitimacy deficit following the coup.

4.2 Centralized Planning and Apartment Constructions

While the government released the first stage of Five Year National Economic Development, the administrative structure centralized its authority to plan and develop the land to the national government.

According to research by Valerie (2007), the City of Seoul became to be placed under the direct jurisdiction of the Prime Minister in 1962. Until 1995, the mayor of Seoul was appointed by the government. By so, the Seoul Metropolitan Government was heavily dependent on the central government as it required permission from the Ministry of Construction for urban development. Urban Planning Act in 1962, granted the government exclusive rights to land development, such as land readjustment and site selection.

President Park appointed Mayor Kim Hyun-ok who was also from the military and known as “*Buldodger Kim*” (Valerie, 2007). The name came from his stubborn and strong military style in planning and execution of Seoul. He prioritized fast-paced developments and pushed ahead the relocation of informal settlements and residents in Seoul to outskirts. The centralized system enabled strong power of mayor and central government in site selection and execution of construction for housing.

4.2.1 Case Study: Mapo Apartment Complex (1964)

The Mapo Apartment Complex, built in 1964 with 642 households in ten six-story buildings, played a significant role in establishing a model of modern apartment housing that became widespread afterward. As shown in the image, the apartment complex was designed as an independent and self-governing community with shared facilities. It was distinctly zoned and disconnected from the surrounding environment and nearby villages. This type of apartment complex, featuring multiple buildings as exemplified by Mapo Apartments, became the norm in South Korea for developing high-density housing.

The government intended the housing to serve as a symbol of modernity and a showcase for promoting the administration and its system. The structure and design aimed to incorporate advanced techniques and introduce a modern lifestyle to achieve these goals.

Park (2003) sharply analyzed the significance and messaging behind the construction of the Mapo Apartments for the military government following the coup. The government needed tangible achievements to distinguish itself from the previous administration and demonstrate its competence compared to North Korea and other corrupt politicians to maintain its authority.

Although the government initially planned for a 10-story apartment complex, it was scaled back to six stories due to opposition from the United States, which cited a lack of proper planning and technology to implement the project. Since the plan relied on U.S. financial support, the South Korean government adjusted its scope. However, the administration still viewed the project as essential for demonstrating the success of the revolution and emphasizing the achievements of the coup ahead of the 1963 presidential and parliamentary elections. Ultimately, the government decided to fund the project independently, without U.S. financial assistance and pushed forward with urgency (Han Kyung, 2024).

Without U.S. support, the Korea Housing Corporation faced financial difficulties and shifted its approach from a long-term rental system to a sales-based distribution model. Residents who had initially expected to rent apartments were instead required to purchase units, a change that was not part of the original plan. This led to establishing a norm of apartment housing to be based on sale, not on rent passing the construction cost to the future residents. Park Byeong-ju, who was the head of the Housing Complex Research Division at the Korea Housing Corporation

at the time, expressed his concerns in an article in *Chosun Ilbo* (April 16, 1967), stating, "The issue lies in the disappearance of the concept of 'rental apartments' and the resulting perception that public rental housing cannot be established under our current circumstances." (Han Kyung, 2024)

In the president's speech at the time of the completion of the Mapo apartment complex in 1964, apartments were expressed as a tool for national modernization. The rapid increase in apartments in Korea symbolically demonstrated the government's willingness to reach a social consensus on an authoritarian government-led growth model.



Mapo Apartment in 1964 (Han Kyung News, 2024)

4.3 Socio-Cultural Impact: Housing Perceptions, Middle Class and Inequality

Initiated by the Mapo Apartment complex construction and plan, Seoul continuously built the same type of housing finally covering the land with a landscape of high-rise apartment blocks that surrounded every corner of the city. It had an impact on forming the perception of housing for Korean people which is a modern and ideal form of living. Park Jung Hee's government promoted the Mapo Apartment complex as an ideal and modern way of living to make it a successful project. This promotion from the government affected the changing perception of the people on the idea of housing which was different from the traditional form of housing.



Seoul, full of apartment complexes (Sisa News, 2024)

Mapo apartment was introduced with ownership instead of a long-time rent system or either affordable system. The first apartment complex plan targeted the upper middle class who could afford to purchase the unit with their capability. As so, apartment housing became a

symbol of the modern middle class. This is not a coincidence that the government targeted the middle class. They were a major driver of economic growth in business and industry of modernizing South Korea such as trained labor, office workers, civil servants, and businessmen (Valérie, 2007). This group, the main driver and beneficiary of growth, was able to achieve wealth accumulation over a short period by buying and selling apartments. This led to a strong agreement from this group of the new middle class on an authoritative government-led growth model.

Referring to the Survey on Seoul Citizen Residential Status conducted by the Seoul Institute (2014) gives clear evidence of the social stratification demonstrated between housing forms. According to the report, the low-income class group is dominantly living in non-apartment housing. The report will be studied to support the argument on how the apartments are at the center of creating social classes in Korean society.

In interviews with residents who do not live in apartments, they expressed concerns that if they are redeveloped into apartments, their children will be ignored by their children living in apartments or their children will have a hard time. As such, the presence or absence of living in an apartment has a simple but powerful symbolic meaning that tells one's social location. As a result, the enthusiasm for apartments led to mass production of apartments, and the Sibum apartment is symbolic of the case (Valérie, 2007).

4.4 Socio-Cultural Impact: Private Sector and Commercialization of Housing

Changes in business and industry were significant. Through large-scale housing construction plans, private construction firms were one of the biggest beneficiaries of those

large-scale developments and National Economic Development. During the first five-year economic development plan from 1962 to 1966, Korea recorded a high annual growth rate of 7.7%. During the same period, the construction industry continued to grow at a whopping 17.4% (HDEC, 2017).

Hyundai Construction (현대건설) was the beneficiary of this apartment housing plans in 1964 Mapo Apartment Construction. Hyundai is a conglomerate (*chaebol*) that began its business with construction. It specialized in repairing U.S. military camp and facilities in 1947. However, it gained its power by taking charge of the construction of Mapo Apartments between 1962 and 1964. Cumings (2001) from his book *'Korea's Place in the Sun'* noted that remarkable growth was possible with the alliance between the private sector and the state. Their mutual relationship was intimate and grew together based on a reward and penalty system from the state government. Companies that fail to meet the goals imposed by the government face penalties, while outstanding performers are rewarded with benefits such as loans, import rights for raw materials and intermediate goods, and land grants.

This system allowed construction companies to reap significant benefits from the large-scale housing policies initiated in the early 1970s.

Not only financially, but they could also make their reputation firm within people's perception of housing and even premium labels on apartments built by them. Construction companies are producing brands for apartments that present premium even explicitly painting brands on the exterior which is exacerbating the commercialization of housing and dismantling the original meaning of home.

In short, Seoul's ubiquitous apartment complexes are compressive representations of the Korean-style development model created by a strong authoritarian government in partnership with private sector to pursue rapid growth.

5. Conclusion

South Korea's housing policies during the early stages of modernization were pivotal in shaping the nation's urban landscape and socio-cultural dynamics. The Mapo Apartment Complex, as a case study, exemplifies how government-led housing initiatives became a symbol of modernity and progress, while also reflecting the authoritarian regime's strategy to solidify its legitimacy and demonstrate rapid economic growth. These policies, influenced by global ideological competition and frameworks like Rostow's modernization model, underscore the role of foreign aid and central planning in driving South Korea's urban transformation.

The introduction of apartment complexes not only addressed Seoul's housing shortages but also redefined societal norms around housing, fostering a new middle-class identity centered on apartment ownership. However, this shift also contributed to social stratification, reinforcing inequalities and establishing a landscape where housing type became a marker of socio-economic status. Furthermore, the collaboration between the government and private construction companies, facilitated by financial incentives and centralized authority, played a critical role in accelerating the commercialization of housing and the dominance of chaebol in urban development.

Ultimately, the Koreanized modernization model, characterized by government-driven initiatives and partnerships with private enterprises, left an enduring impact on South Korea's urban planning and socio-economic framework. While it succeeded in addressing immediate post-war challenges and projecting a narrative of progress, it also laid the foundation for ongoing issues of social inequality and housing affordability. This analysis not only sheds light on the complexities of South Korea's modernization but also invites reflection on the long-term consequences of rapid, top-down urban development strategies.

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History and Theory of Planning
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Final Paper

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Word count: 3798